

What funding cuts mean for PBS and NPR

Stations in big cities are likely to reduce staff. Rural outlets may not survive.

By Kaitlyn Huamani and Stephen Battaglio

Ken Burns has made more than 30 documentaries and won multiple Emmys. But without funding from public television, his educational programming such as “The Civil War” and “Baseball” might never have existed, he told “PBS News Hour” in an interview Thursday.

Even today, the acclaimed filmmaker whose works — including his upcoming project “The American Revolution” — are broadcast on PBS, said his films get around 20% of their budgets from the Corp. for Public Broadcasting, the body Congress recently voted to defund.

Projects that receive a higher percentage of their funding through public media “just won’t be able to be made,” Burns said. “And so there’ll be less representation by all the different kinds of filmmakers. People com-

ing up will have an impossible time getting started.”

The U.S. Senate this week passed the Trump administration’s proposal to cancel \$9 billion in federal funding previously allocated for foreign aid and public broadcasting, and the House of Representatives approved the package after midnight Friday, sending it to President Trump’s desk.

The Corp. for Public Broadcasting, which administers the funds for NPR radio stations and PBS TV affiliates, is on track to lose \$1.1 billion that had previously been budgeted for the next two years.

The impact of those cuts will be deeply felt across both NPR and PBS, leaders of both organizations told The Times. Layoffs and reduced programming are expected, and the blows will disproportionately strike smaller markets that rely more heavily on federal funding.

“This is going to hit hardest in the places that need it the most,” said Gabriel Kahn, a professor at the USC Annenberg School for Communication and Journalism.

Stations in smaller markets are staffed significantly [See **PBS**, A12]



CARLIN STIEHL Los Angeles Times



GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

L.A. COUNTY Sheriff Robert Luna, top, said the deputies were “the best of the best.” Above, firefighters raise a flag at the Biscailuz Center Training Academy.

BLAST KILLS 3 LAWMEN AT EAST L.A. SITE

The arson unit deputies were moving ordnance at sheriff’s training academy.

By Richard Winton, Nathan Solis, Hannah Fry, Christopher Buchanan and Connor Sheets

Three deputies were killed Friday in an explosion at the Los Angeles County Sheriff’s Department’s Biscailuz Center Training Academy in East L.A., the deadliest incident for the agency in more than 160 years.

Deputies with the arson explosives detail, an elite unit within the Sheriff’s Department, were moving ordnance in the training center’s parking lot about 7:30 a.m. when the blast occurred. The explosive device had been collected in Santa Monica on Thursday, law enforcement sources told The Times.

The deputies, who have not been publicly identified, died at the scene. They had served between 19 and 33 years with the department, Los Angeles County Sheriff Robert Luna said during a Friday morning news conference.

“They’re the best of the best,” Luna said of the agency’s special enforcement bureau. “And the individuals who work our arson explosives detail, they have years of training. ... They are fantastic experts, and unfortunately, I lost three of them today.”

He said it will take time — possibly weeks or months — [See **Explosion**, A7]

Weather warnings met with shrugs

Texas floods and L.A. firestorms leave meteorologists with regret and questions.

By Rong-Gong Lin II

Meteorologists warned about the chance of flash floods days before Texas’ Fourth of July disaster that killed at least 133. Yet, local officials in the hardest-hit areas say they were shocked by the scale of the devastation.

“I have cried on multiple occasions,” Chris Suchan, chief meteorologist with WOAI-TV Channel 4, the NBC affiliate in San Antonio, wrote in a recent Facebook post. “At times, I’ve been overwhelmed with forecaster regret that I could have done more the night before in my weather report.”

Forecasters often issue alerts for possible flooding, landslides and “red flag” fire warnings multiple times a year. Sometimes, those warnings are followed by major catastrophes, but other times they are not.

And that has led some to become complacent, rather than heeding the alerts.

Two massive disasters this year — the Texas floods and Los Angeles firestorms — are leading some to grapple with the question of how to get officials and the public to care and take action.

In the case of Texas, Suchan said he is experiencing what he calls “forecaster regret.”

That’s despite having presented viewers a weather forecast showing “a signal of localized flash flooding” on the afternoon of July 3 — hours before the disaster struck. During the 6 p.m. broadcast later that day, Suchan pointed to an area “where we could see storms develop and then train over the same area. ... And that is a classic flash-flooding signal here in ‘Flash Flood Alley.’”

The disconnect between available warnings and the action officials and the public take has been seen re-

Bukele’s critics flee El Salvador



SALVADOR MELENDEZ Associated Press

RUTH Eleonora Lopez, a leader of a human rights group in El Salvador, at a court hearing post-arrest.

Droves of journalists, human rights activists and others leave out of fear of president.

By Kate Linticum

MEXICO CITY — They have fled to Guatemala, Mexico, Costa Rica and Spain. Most left in a hurry with few possessions, unsure of when — or whether — they would be able to return home.

As El Salvador cracks down on dissent, jailing critics

ics of President Nayib Bukele, droves of human rights activists, journalists and other members of civil society are leaving the country out of fear.

More than 100 people have fled in recent months — the biggest exodus of political exiles since the country’s bloody civil war. That puts El Salvador in the company of other authoritarian Latin American nations, including Nicaragua and Venezuela, where dissent has been criminalized and critics choose between prison and exile.

[See **Critics**, A4]

An owl-culling plan hits a roadblock

Federal plan to kill thousands of one species to save others faces bipartisan opposition

By Lila Seidman



DON RYAN Associated Press

A NORTHERN spotted owl in Oregon. The imperiled species has been out-competed by the barred owl.

cluding one study that would remove barred owls from more than 192,000 acres in Mendocino and Sonoma counties.

Two were nixed before federal funding was allocated and never got off the ground, said Peter Tira, a spokesperson for the state wildlife agency. Another, a study in collaboration with University of Maryland biologists to better understand barred owl dispersal patterns in western forests, was nearly complete when terminated.

“Under President Donald J. Trump’s leadership, we are eliminating wasteful programs, cutting unnecessary costs and ensuring every dollar serves a clear purpose,” a spokesperson for the U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service said in a statement when asked whether the grants had been terminated.

Another lever would be for Congress to overturn the owl-kill plan altogether using the Congressional Review Act.

The General Accounting Office concluded in a late-May decision that the plan is subject to that act, sometimes used by new presidential administrations to reverse rules issued in the

[See **Owls**, A9]

Is curtain falling on late-night TV hosts?

By Stephen Battaglio

The shocking cancellation of “The Late Show With Stephen Colbert” is a sign that time is running out for one of TV’s most beloved formats.

The late-night talk show was invented in the 1950s as a way for networks to own their own programming rather than have it provided by sponsors. Now, amid shrinking audiences and a politically turbulent climate for free speech, the familiar desk-and-sofa tableau is in serious trouble.

CBS announced Thursday that the upcoming 2025-26 TV season for “The Late Show” will be its last. Executives blamed the cancellation on financial concerns felt across all network late-night shows. Last year, NBC cut “The Tonight Show Starring Jimmy Fallon” to four nights a week while “Late Night With Seth Meyers” cut its live band.

Still, industry veterans were bewildered by the timing.

It’s hard to imagine Paramount Global executives did not anticipate blowback from announcing the move days after Colbert blasted

[See **Late night**, A12]

Trump sues Dow Jones, Murdoch
President disputes Wall Street Journal story about his alleged letter to Epstein. **NATION**, A6

Watters admits Newsom mistake
Fox News host says he misunderstood governor’s post about call. **BUSINESS**, A10

ICE raids move to Sacramento
“No such thing as a sanctuary state,” U.S. border official says. **CALIFORNIA**, B1

Weather
Partly sunny. L.A. Basin: 83/63. **B8**

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Opinion Voices **A13**

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